

years, he has added Ranveer Singh as *Simmba* (2018) and Akshay Kumar as *Sooryavanshi* (2021). And he's not done with the good Maharashtrian cop act yet. At a promotional event last year, he silenced critics who wanted him to go beyond the machismo and add a 'shero' to the Universe. Enter Deepika Padukone, who Shetty declared will be his lady Singham in the next instalment. Shetty is also taking his cop-verse to the digital platform. *Indian Police Force* on Amazon Prime Video will see Sidharth Malhotra don the khaki. "I want to make the biggest action series," Shetty said at the announcement. "We are seeing a lot of series coming from abroad. [There's] nothing wrong in it but something has to go from India [to the world], and that's what I want to do."



"THE BIGGEST THING A UNIVERSE DOES IS IT MAKES YOU FEEL A PART OF IT. YOU ARE INCLINED TO GO TO THE THEATRE TO SEE THE FILM"

—DINESH VIJAN, *Maddock Films*

Amazon Prime Video is also in the midst of building its own spy universe. To begin with, there is *Citadel*. After the US version of the action drama led by Priyanka Chopra Jonas and Richard Madden drops in late April, there will be *Citadel* iterations in Italy, India, Spain and Mexico, each referencing the other. In the Indian version, Varun Dhawan and Samantha Ruth Prabhu will be spies fighting the good fight in the Raj & DK-helmed show.

Universe-building, though, needs some serious thought. Writers have to find clever ways to depict characters that can jump different worlds and pen expandable narratives. Having a connection alone is not enough, the story also has to be compelling and engaging. For that to happen, "the characters must